an interesting pattern: the seats won by the SNLD are concentrated in the north, where the SSA-North is based, and to the east of southern Shan State, where the RCSS/SSA-S is strong. In southern Shan State, the SNLD did not have the advantage and the NLD won most of the seats (with the exception of the area controlled by the PNO and a pocket won by the USDP). This pattern requires an explanation.

As observed in the Pa-O areas, the PNO is the dominant actor, the political economy that feeds the party is very well established, and the spoils from ceasefire capitalism trickle down to the village tract leaders who have direct authority over the villagers. However, the benefit chain broke down in the southern Shan State. The SNDP did not receive strong financial support from the regime and it lacked the influence to force the issue at the village level. While the SNLD is close to the RCSS/SSA-S, the benefit and power chains broke down at the micro level. The ceasefire dividend did trickle down to the lieutenant colonel, but then he became a property developer. Moreover, the SNLD does not have soft power at its disposal. Its appeal is self-determination and democracy, but the NLD shares much the same values and it has soft power in democracy icon Aung San Suu Kyi. This explains why the SNLD could only get seats in the north and east, and failed in the tussle with the NLD in the west of the state.

CONCLUSION

What are the contributions and implications of the analysis for the study of the political order in Pa-O areas and southern Shan State? Drawing a distinction between the frontier and border to examine the political order allows the focus to shift from the state onto local political actors. In the frontier, devolution of power to local warlords is tolerated, and through them some form of order can be restored in areas where there was previously conflict. The analysis also links the co-optation process at the macro level with the implementation and maintenance of order at the micro level to establish how ceasefire capitalism advances state control in the frontier.

The PNO experience in retaining its seats in the 2015 election demonstrates that ceasefire capitalism could indeed be used to consolidate state control in the frontier; however, the SNDP experience is the opposite. What accounts for the different outcomes? At first glance, there is an obvious